Which AI Tool Fits Your Project?

A decision flow for freelance researchers and solopreneurs handling client data

START HERE

Check Your Agreement With the Client.

It decides what you're allowed to use.

DECISION 1

Does Any of this Apply?

- Raw data has PII: recordings, transcripts with names and workplaces
- The data could be re-identified
- Regulations apply (GDPR, HIPAA, etc.)
- The contract requires documented data security for your tools
- You need traceability and auditability
- High volume: 100 transcripts, not 10

yes

OUTCOME

Purpose-Built Research Tech

Best when you can see the data processors list and the data processing agreements between the tool and whatever sits underneath it.

Still read the terms. Some restech tools are just wrappers around an LLM.

no

DECISION 2

Is There Anything in the Data the Client Would Consider Confidential?

You're here with anonymized, low-volume data and nothing stricter required.

yes

OUTCOME

Business Subscription

Fine when the customer has approved it, the sensitivity is business confidentiality rather than personal data, and nobody requires something stricter.

no

OUTCOME

Consumer Subscription *(aka Independent Researcher)*

Fine when the client has approved it. Turn model training off: a reasonable floor for non-identifiable data.

Whichever Tool You Land On, Check It

Three Questions for Any Tech

1. What is this vendor allowed to do with the data, and who defines that?

2. How long is the data kept after I'm done, and can I make it be deleted immediately?

3. Which sub-processors or models sit underneath?

Look For These in the Fine Print

Terms and privacy policy; answers can be split across both.

- Who is responsible for the data at each stage of processing
- Who does what with the data
- Whether it's easy for you to delete the data
- How long data is stored
- Where it's stored: locales differ on security and privacy rules

Why Turning Training Off Isn't The Whole Picture

Retention: an LLM company can keep a conversation for a time after you delete it, and one flagged for human review can stay flagged (Google). **Processing:** opting out of training may not cover product improvement, advertising, safety, security and compliance uses (Microsoft Copilot). **Plan:** consumer subscriptions don't carry the same terms as business ones.

Source: Zontziry Johnson, “Is turning off that training setting enough? The complex world of data retention and processing,” October 8, 2026.